

cheaper drugs translate into wider treatment, and whether that expansion makes any difference to India's epidemic of obesity, diabetes and cardiovascular disease.

"The branded versions were priced at ₹15,000 or more a month, limiting use to a narrow slice of wealthy urban patients. Some generic formulations are now available for a fraction of that amount," says health economist Arup Mitra, Professor and Dean at South Asian University. India has the infrastructure, the science and the need, he adds. "The system must now prove it is ready to absorb it."

Besides, there are fears that the gold rush could provide unscrupulous elements an opportunity to prey on the vulnerable.

SCALE OF THE PROBLEM

There is no question about the need for the drug in India. According

to the International Diabetes Federation's Diabetes Atlas 2025, more than 136 million Indians live with diabetes, the largest absolute burden in the world.

Data from the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR)-INDIAB study published in 2023 estimates that nearly 136 million are pre-diabetic, highlighting the size of the at-risk population.

To add to that, the National Family Health Survey-5 shows that 24% of women and 23% of men in India are overweight or obese, with higher prevalence in urban areas. The World Health Organization's (WHO's) Global Obesity Observatory projects these numbers will rise sharply through the decade. Plus, the ICMR 2023 estimates that cardiovascular disease accounts for nearly 28% of all deaths in India.

"Taken together, these

numbers point to a disease burden that existing interventions have struggled to address at scale," says Dr Anoop Misra, Chairman of Fortis C-DOC Hospital for Diabetes and Allied Sciences and Director of the National Diabetes Obesity and Cholesterol Foundation.

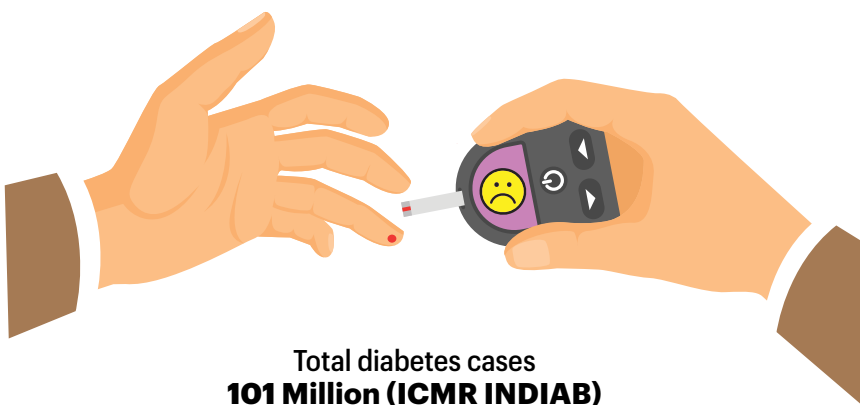
"This is a social legacy that reduces both patient demand for treatment and physician willingness to initiate it. In Tier II and III cities, and across much of rural India, the framing of obesity as a disease requiring long-term medical management has barely taken hold," Dr Misra adds.

AFFORDABILITY

Novo Nordisk spent decades and significant capital developing GLP-1 therapies—medications that help lower blood sugar levels and in losing weight. The pricing reflected the investment and economics of

DIABETES BURDEN

India has over 101 million people with diabetes.
An equal number are at risk



Total diabetes cases
101 Million (ICMR INDIAB)

Urban
prevalence
~16–20%

Rural
prevalence
~8–12% (rising)

Undiagnosed
~50% of cases

Diabetes in working-age population
High concentration (30–60 yrs)

Growth trend
Rapid increase over last decade

India global rank
Among highest globally

Associated hypertension
~25–30% adults

Cardiovascular risk linkage
Major contributor to heart disease

Obesity-linked diabetes
Strong correlation

Treatment adherence
Below 50% in many cases

SOURCE ICMR-INDIAB STUDY (2023); MINISTRY OF HEALTH & FAMILY WELFARE